

The Long Winter's Night

The snowlit fjords of the north run deep and blue between white mountains and dark green pines, dotted with cosy longhouses whose windows glow warm amber against the snow. Above them arches the Great World Tree, and on clear nights the sky dances with the colours of the aurora. The fjords are full of gentle wonders: a chattering squirrel who carries messages along the tree, two wise ravens, light spirits who dance in the dark, and frost giants who look fearsome but are mostly just cold and lonely. Here a hero is not the strongest or the loudest, but the one who keeps a warm heart, thinks things through, and shares the fire. The grandest deeds are done by being clever and brave and kind, and even a giant met with a friendly word often turns out lonelier than it is fierce.



The Long Winter's Night

Read aloud, or let an older child read it themselves. Pause at each question so the heroes can decide together. There are no wrong answers here, only braver ideas to try.

Before you begin

It was the longest night of the year, the deep heart of winter, when the dark stretches on so far you begin to wonder if the sun has forgotten the way home. And on this night of all nights, the great hearth-fire of the Hearth Hall had gone out. The longhouse had fallen cold. The amber windows that always glowed across the snow were dark, and one by one, all down the valley, the warmth was slipping away.

Edda the Saga-Keeper called the two of you to her side, her old eyes bright in the gloom. "You have clever heads and warm hearts," she said, "and on a night like this that is worth more than any axe. Will you carry the warmth back to us before dawn?"

Into your hands she pressed three gifts: the Everwarm Ember, a coal that never goes cold; a ball of bright red yarn; and a soft honey bun, still warm from the embers. "Remember," she said, "in these fjords we do not win by being the strongest. We win by being clever, brave, and kind. Cross the Rainbow Bridge to the high halls, and light the world's warmth again."

What is your hero name? Which quality will you carry: Wit, Courage, or Heart?

Stop 1: The Frozen Fjord



You stepped out under a sky thick with cold stars, and before you lay the Frozen Fjord: a long, deep arm of water turned smooth and silver between the dark mountains. It looked solid enough, but the moment you set foot on it, the ice gave a long, low groan, and somewhere beneath you something cracked and settled. To rush across all together, in one heavy bunch, would be asking too much of it.

Far overhead the Two Ravens, Thought and Memory, wheeled against the stars and watched you with patient, knowing eyes.

How will you cross without the ice giving way? Could you spread out so your weight is shared, and step softly, treating the ice gently? Could you hold hands and go together, or lay the red yarn down as a guide through the dark? What is your plan?

By spreading out and stepping gently, with the red yarn unspooling bright behind you, you crossed the fjord as kindly as you could, and the ice held you the whole way. You reached the far shore with frost on your eyelashes and your hearts beating quick and proud.

Stop 2: The Lonely Frost Giant



And there, past the fjord, sat a giant: huge, hewn from pale blue ice, taller than the Hearth Hall itself, blocking the road with his folded arms and a face set as hard as a glacier. Your heart thumped. For a moment he looked like the end of the whole adventure.

Then he shivered, and his great icy shoulders sagged, and you understood. He was not angry. He was lonely. No traveller had ever stopped to speak with him, and the long cold years alone had made him gruff and sad.

This was never a fight, and no one here raises a hand. What kindness could you show him? You have a warm honey bun to share. You could ask him his name, or offer him a place beside the Everwarm Ember, or simply tell him he need not be alone tonight. What do you do?

When you offered him your kindness, the giant's hard face cracked, not with anger but with wonder, and warmed slowly into a smile. "You stayed," he whispered, as though he could hardly believe it. "You are my friends." And he rose, gentle as falling snow, and came along beside you into the dark.

Stop 3: The Rainbow Bridge



At the foot of the mountains shimmered the Rainbow Bridge, a great arch of soft colours rising out of the snow towards the high halls of the gods. It was beautiful and a little frightening, for it was said to hold firm only for those who cross it with a kind and honest heart, and to dim and waver beneath any other.

Will you cross? You carry the Everwarm Ember, warm and true, and beside you walks a friend who was lonely an hour ago and is lonely no longer. Step out together, honestly and gently, and trust the bridge to know your hearts.

As you stepped out, the bridge brightened under your feet, colour blooming with every step, and it carried all of you, giant and all, safely up to the high hall. There you lifted the Everwarm Ember high, and its glow leapt outward, and the world's warmth caught light once more.

Dawn and Warmth



Far below, the change began. One hearth, then another, then a hundred, the fires relit themselves all down the snowy valley, until every amber window glowed warm again and the cold lost its grip on the long night. Slowly, softly, the first pale gold of dawn climbed over the white mountains, and the longest night of the year ended not in darkness but in light.

High above, the Aurora Spirits woke and danced for joy, ribbons of teal and green and purple rippling across the brightening sky. The Lonely Frost Giant stood among you, warm at last and smiling, with friends he had waited his whole long life to find. And from the high halls, Freya the Kind looked down and smiled. You had done it, and you had done it together: with your wit, with your courage, and above all with your heart. Well done, heroes of the Snowlit Fjords.

My Adventure Sheet

Draw your hero

My name

I am a hero of

My energy stars (colour one in when you spend it)



My magics



My magic is

It can



My magic is

It can



My magic is

It can

What I carry

Notes

Here nobody loses. If a try does not work, find another way.

Wits and Wonder

Story Pack

<https://github.com/agigante80/wits-and-wonder>

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